

# Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



A weather balloon is carried to a parking lot by Joan Morrow before being launched during a citizen science initiative event on Monday as part of a discussion to address flooding in the Chatham neighborhood. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

## ‘The cavalry is coming’

Scientists join the fight against basement flooding in the Chatham neighborhood

**By Nara Schoenberg**  
Chicago Tribune

When Nedra Sims Fears was growing up in Chatham in the 1960s and ‘70s, the basement of her family home flooded at least six times.

Twice, the water rose so high that it triggered an electrical fire and her family had to move out during extensive renovations. Mementos from Fears’ early years — in a close-knit neighborhood that embraced hard work, education and block parties — were lost forever.

“We really just don’t have that many memories,” Fears said.

“Most things, if it wasn’t water-logged, it was smoke-damaged. My daughter found a picture of me as a child — and there’s not many of them.”

Now Fears is fighting back, as part of a coalition of community leaders, university scientists and concerned citizens who have joined together to answer a question that has haunted this South Side neighborhood for decades: Why is it that Chatham experiences some of the worst basement flooding in the city?

Volunteers are measuring rainfall in their yards, a local nonprofit is rallying support, and scientists at universities

including the University of Illinois, Chicago State and Northwestern are gathering data with soil moisture sensors, radar, weather balloons, and ground-water probes.

The scientists are participating as part of the Department of Energy’s five-year, \$25 million Community Research on Climate and Urban Science (CROCUS) project, which aims to better understand and predict urban weather challenges in Chicago, including heat waves and flooding.

Similar programs have faced threats of defunding during President Donald Trump’s cost-cut-

ting campaigns.

“Normal weather models don’t incorporate urban dynamics particularly well, so we’re using new families and types of models — including machine learning and artificial intelligence-type models — which have never been operated at the scale needed to really capture what’s happening in cities,” said Max Berkelhammer, associate professor of earth and environmental sciences at the University of Illinois Chicago.

The scientists approached Fears, who said she jumped at the chance to get involved. Humboldt

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## Hearings on budget bill begin in House

Package focuses on \$5 trillion tax break, steep spending cuts

**By Lisa Mascaro and Kevin Freking**  
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — Tax breaks tallying more than \$5 trillion — but also sizable reductions in Medicaid health care, food stamps for older Americans and green energy strategies to fight climate change — were all up for debate Tuesday as the House Republicans launched marathon public hearings on their “big, beautiful bill.”

Republicans are working to push President Donald Trump’s signature legislative package through a gantlet of committee hearings over mounting opposition from Democrats, advocacy groups and even some wary Republicans themselves.

Right from the start, one hearing was immediately disrupted by protesters shouting down what the top Democrat on the committee called “cruel” cuts to Medicaid and other programs.

“People feel very strong because they know they’re losing their health care,” said Rep. Frank Pallone, D-N.J., on the Energy & Commerce Committee. He asked for the police to refrain from making arrests, noting that some of the people protesting were disabled.

It’s the biggest political and legislative debate for the Republicans leading Congress since Trump’s first term, setting up a career-defining clash over the nation’s priorities — some \$5 trillion in tax breaks, including the president’s promises for no taxes on tips, Social Security income and car loan interest, offset by \$1.9 trillion in tax savings largely from

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### INSIDE



CHICAGO TRIBUNE ARCHIVE

## ‘Shoeless’ Joe reinstated

“Shoeless” Joe Jackson and Pete Rose were reinstated by baseball Commissioner Rob Manfred on Tuesday, making both eligible for the Hall of Fame. Jackson, above, was among the eight White Sox players banned for throwing the 1919 World Series in what became known as the Black Sox Scandal. Rose allegedly bet on the Reds as a player and manager. **Chicago Sports**

## Bringing German wine to Chicago

RieslingKenner has quietly assumed the role of an evangelist for Germany’s most underappreciated wines. **Food & Health**

## A haunting call: ‘Jayden and Mommy are dead’

Testimony recounts events during trial of alleged killer of boy, 11

**By Madeline Buckley**  
Chicago Tribune

Kassidy Miles rose early on March 13, 2024. He kissed the two sleeping boys goodbye and set off for O’Hare International Airport to start his shift at 7 a.m.

About 45 minutes later, he said, he received a video call that made him scream. His 5-year-old son had dialed him up on an iPad and asked him to come home.

“Jayden and Mommy are dead,” the boy told his father.

The boy referred to his older brother, 11-year-old Jayden Perkins, who was fatally stabbed in his apartment in the 5900 block of North Ravenswood Avenue while trying to protect his pregnant mother. His mother, Laterria Smith, who at the time was Miles’ fiancée, was seriously injured but survived.

Charged in the slaying is Crosetti Brand, 39, who faces charges of murder, attempted murder, home invasion and aggravated domestic battery. Brand is representing himself in the trial, which began Friday with jury selection and continued Monday with opening statements, during which he told the jury he acted in self defense.

On Tuesday, Miles took the stand, choking up as he described

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Lisa Fleischmann stands in her Trump Truth Store on May 4 in Huntley. The store’s landlord has been cited for sign ordinance and building code violations, according to public records. Fleischmann says she’s being unfairly targeted for her political beliefs. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

### HUNTLEY

## Trump store may close over code issues, but owner says it’s political

**By Angie Leventis Lourgos**  
Chicago Tribune

A 6-foot-tall inflatable Donald Trump gives two thumbs up to passersby outside the Trump Truth Store in far northwest suburban Huntley, which sells all varieties of Trump-themed merchandise from Make America Great Again T-shirts to DOGE baseball caps.

But the replica of the controversial 47th president — along with the business it’s promoting — is on the verge of losing a

hard-fought campaign against routine municipal oversight.

In true Trump fashion, the store’s owner is refusing to concede defeat and has vowed to fight suburbia’s deep state.

The Trump Truth Store has been accused of violating building sign ordinance and building codes over the past six months, according to public records. Huntley village officials say the blow-up likeness of the store’s namesake, as well as a temporary banner and outdoor merchandise that stretch into the public right-of-

way, all violate municipal code.

Several citations were filed in January against the store’s landlord, who is now threatening the business with eviction in McHenry County Circuit Court. A bench trial in the eviction case is scheduled for next month.

Trump Truth Store owner Lisa Fleischmann claims she’s being unfairly targeted by village officials for her political beliefs.

“We have to show people

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